

Now Boarding – Life Near an Airport is for the Birds

By: Chaz Wilke - Staff Writer



If you position yourself near the top of the Hollywood hills on a clear day, you can see the planes lining up for landing at LAX. Staggered two minutes apart at peak times, from the distance you're standing you can see a line of four or five planes on the horizon slowly curving towards the ground. From this distance the planes appear to hang silently in the air.

If you were in El Segundo, much closer to LAX, a plane coming in for landing every two minutes becomes an unnerving cacophony.

Living near an airport, under the landing pattern of jumbo jets requires a certain amount of patience. Noise can feel never ending. But noise isn't the only detriment to a peaceful home. Planes tend to release toxins into the air. And with hundreds of planes taking off and landing each day, that fact may force you to reconsider living so close to a busy travel hub.

This advertisement for 'SOLAR ME HOME' has a bright blue background. At the top, it asks 'Electricity bill too high?' in white text. Below this, 'GO SOLAR' is written in large, bold yellow letters, followed by 'Find Installers!' in a script font with a curved arrow. A white rounded rectangle contains the text 'Your Zip Code' next to a green circle with the word 'GO' in white. The bottom of the ad features a photograph of a smiling family (a man, a woman, and two children) in front of a house with solar panels on the roof. The 'SOLAR ME HOME' logo is in the top right corner.

(<https://solarmehome.com/?cid=28806>)

This advertisement for 'pursuemortgage' has a teal background. It features a silhouette of a family walking under a large tree on the left, and a house on the right. The company name 'pursuemortgage' is in white and yellow text. Below it, the text 'Thinking About Refinancing?' is written in white, and a yellow button at the bottom says 'Find Lenders Now' in black text.

(<https://pursuemortgage.com/?cid=28806>)



Noise

When buying a home, there's an implied wish of peace and quiet. And the price tag for homes near an airport may seem tantalizing. Perhaps that is when the "too good to be true" feeling may set in.

Consider the distance your potential new home sits from the airport. Less than a mile? More than 10? It may make a huge difference. Two recent observational studies looked at the relationship between noise pollution and the increased risk for cardiovascular disease.

Both studies concluded an increased risk of possible health effects directly related to aircraft noise. The first paper studied 3.6 million people living near Heathrow airport in London. Those living closest, in the noisiest residential area, saw "an elevated risk (<http://onforb.es/1I9pe1Q>) for stroke, coronary heart disease, and cardiovascular disease."

The paper concluded that there is a "dose-response relationship," which means that the closer you live to the airport, the more aircraft noise you experience in your home, the higher the risk you run for developing heart problems.

The second paper analyzed 6 million Medicare recipients in the U.S. who lived near 89 different airports around the country. Larry Husten, a contributor for Forbes reports:

"They found that people who lived in zip codes with the top 10% of noise exposure had a significant increase in the risk of hospital admission for cardiovascular disease (after adjusting for age, sex, race, zip code level socioeconomic status and demographics, zip code level air pollution, and roadway density.)"

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Air Pollution

It's been nearly two decades since lead was allowed in automobile gasoline. It had taken many years since the passage of the Clean Air Act of 1970 to change what can legally be included in what we pay for at the pump.

Lead creates a nasty neurological effect, can damage the central nervous system, impair hearing, cause anemia and can manifest violent behavior (<http://bit.ly/1L3i8ik>) later in life. "Even at infinitesimal levels in the blood, lead has been linked to ADHD," says Michael Behar of On-Earth.org. It's dangerous and potentially fatal for all age groups, and it is still allowed for use in airline fuel.

"When the Oregon Department of Environmental Quality surveyed the airport in 2005, it found a lead cloud hovering above Hillsboro [home to Portland-Hillsboro Airport], a circular plume spanning 25 square miles," says Behar.

Twenty-five square miles covers a staggering amount of homes surrounding the airport. And lead is only the beginning. Recent studies indicate an increased cancer risk for those living near an airport. Volatile organic compounds (VOCs) are included in the slurry of airborne toxins spewed by planes on their flight path. These VOCs are directly linked to an increase in cancer rates of residents in surrounding areas.

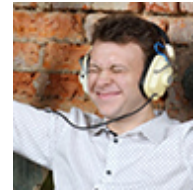
Researchers looked at the residences surrounding the Seattle-Tacoma airport (SeaTac). "Health workers also found high numbers of cases of the brain cancer called glioblastoma. Normally fatal, it ends the life of only one in 25,000 people, but the city of SeaTac which has a population of 23,000, had experienced at least five deaths from the disease," says (<http://dailym.ai/1HAISZP>). Andrea Perry, a reporter for DailyMail.

If you're asking yourself how something like this isn't widely reported, you're not alone. "The question is why hasn't any research been done. No one seems to be taking this threat seriously and we really should be asking more questions about the effects on health caused by the aviation industry," says a spokesman for Transport 2000, the organization leading this latest round of research.



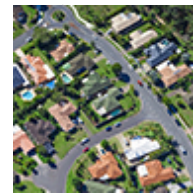
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Unfortunately, the exponential increase in aviation is likely to increase these figures. It is reported that air travel in 2015 has more than doubled since 1995, and if current trends continue by 2050 “passenger-kilometers flown could grow to between five and nine times the figure for 1995,” predicts Transport 2000.

Takeaway

This information should give pause for anyone looking to buy a home near an airport. But beyond health risks and daily noise disruptions, there's one more little problem with living near an airport. As Realtor.com [reminds](http://bit.ly/1Gz7VdT) (<http://bit.ly/1Gz7VdT>) us, “a home very close to the physical border of the airport might decrease in value should the airport decide to expand or add additional runways that create new flight paths.”

So even if you're okay with the potential damaging health effects of living close to an airport, you may find you'll be forced out of your home if the airport decides to expand or restructure its flight paths. In case you were wondering, evictions due to airport expansions [happen](http://bit.ly/1cQukan) (<http://bit.ly/1cQukan>) [relatively](http://bit.ly/1QSQGWh) (<http://bit.ly/1QSQGWh>) [often](http://bit.ly/1Mwj3bw) (<http://bit.ly/1Mwj3bw>).

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